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New law allows human composting + No more 'side shows' + Punishing hate symbols equally

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Good morning and welcome to the A.M. Alert!

NEWSOM SIGNS HUMAN COMPOSTING BILL

Well that's one way to reduce carbon emissions in California.

Gov. Gavin Newsom over the weekend signed AB 351 into law, allowing people to have their remains composted rather than buried or cremated after death.

The bill was authored by Assemblywoman Cristina Garcia, D-Bell Gardens, who championed human composting, referred to as Natural Organic Reduction (NOR), as an environmentally friendly option for Californians considering their death plans.

"The wildfires, extreme drought and heat dome we just experienced remind us that climate change is real and detrimental and we must do everything we can to reduce methane and CO2 emissions. This is an alternative method of final disposition that won't contribute emissions into our atmosphere and will actually capture CO2 in our soil and trees. For each individual who chooses NOR over conventional burial or cremation, the process saves the equivalent of one metric ton of carbon from entering the environment," Garcia said in a statement.

Two-thirds of Californians (66.7%) opt to be cremated, according to estimates from the National Funeral Directors Association shared by Garcia's office. That's a lot of carbon to send up into the air. How much?

According to Garcia's office, if every Californian were to choose composting over cremation, the state would see 2.5 million fewer metric tons of carbon within a decade; that's the equivalent of energy output required to power 225,000 homes for a year.

See bureau reporter Stephen Hobbs' story on the bill-signing here.

NO MORE PARKING LOT 'SIDE SHOWS'

California will crack down on street racing and "side shows," where drivers do dangerous stunts in parking lots, after Newsom signed AB 2000 into law, giving courts the authority to suspend driver's licenses for people caught participating.

The bill was authored by Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Woodland Hills, who said in a statement that street racing cuts young lives short.

"Communities in the San Fernando Valley and across California are sick and tired of this reckless behavior. I'm grateful for Governor Newsom's leadership on cracking down on this dangerous activity and signing this commonsense measure that will save lives across our state," Gabriel said.

The bill had bipartisan bonafides; Assemblyman Vince Fong, R-Bakersfield, was a joint author of the measure.

"There are countless stories every week throughout California about illegal street races and dangerous sideshows shutting down streets, causing accidents, damaging neighborhoods, and endangering lives," Fong said in a statement.

California saw a dangerous uptick in illegal street racing during the COVID pandemic, when roads were largely empty due to stay-at-home orders. In 2020, the California Highway Patrol responded to more than 25,000 street racing-related calls, an increase of 3,500 from the year prior.

CALIFORNIA STANDARDIZES PENALTIES FOR HATE IMAGERY

Prior to Newsom signing AB 2282 into law, penalties for brandishing a swastika, a noose or a flaming cross with the intent to terrorize varied depending on the particular item used. Now, it's a crime punishable by up to three years in prison and a fine of up to $10,000, regardless of the iconography used.

The bill's author, Assemblywoman Rebecca Bauer-Kahan, D-Orinda, said in a statement that hate symbols are violent and terrifying and that their use should be punished equally.

"With hate crimes increasing across the state, it is critical to recognize the power and destructiveness of these symbols, and restrict their use equally," she said.

The bill also increases the number of locations where such symbols are banned, to include K-12 schools, colleges, cemeteries, places of worship, places of employment, private property, public parks, public spaces, and public facilities.

Finally, the bill explicitly identifies the Nazi swastika as a hate symbol and not swastikas associated with the religions of Hinduism, Buddhism or Jainism.

"We're thrilled that we are making history in California with historic language recognizing the significance of the swastika with the signature of AB 22822," said Samir Kalra, managing director of the Hindu American Foundation, in a statement. "We thank Assemblymember Bauer-Kahan for her continued leadership on this issue. This is historic legislation to better protect the religious practices of Hindus, Jains, Buddhists, and Zoroastrians."

QUOTE OF THE DAY

"Being young in politics sadly make you age more rapidly."

- Assemblyman Alex Lee, D-San Jose, via Twitter.

Best of The Bee:

Gov. Gavin Newsom wants to debate a Republican — but the one he seems most eager to take on is about 2,500 miles away, via Lindsey Holden. When Gov. Gavin Newsom stood in front of cameras in a Vallejo parking lot on Friday to celebrate a sweeping package of new climate legislation, some environmentalists and urban planners noticed that one bill was conspicuously missing — Assembly Bill 2097, via Maggie Angst. California employers will soon be banned from screening workers for marijuana use in most circumstances, under a new law signed by Gov. Gavin Newsom, via Andrew Sheeler.Republicans believe the latest grim news about higher prices is fresh, stark evidence that Democrats are presiding over a deeply troubled economy, via David Lightman.Fifty-six Glenn County retirees likely will have to return part of their pensions to CalPERS due to a mistake their employer made that inflated their retirement benefits. The California Public Employees' Retirement System is moving to reduce the retirees' pensions despite a new state law aimed at holding employers — rather than employees — responsible for pension mistakes, via Wes Venteicher.

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